

Transitive and Intransitive English Verbs - Blurb

A Quick Reference Guide

People often ask, *why* there are two words: "see and look," "hear" and "listen."

One way of describing the difference between transitive and intransitive verbs, in English is that they are different kinds of words that naturally take two different functions.

External vs. Personal

A transitive word is more simple: "I hear you."

An intransitive word describes a relationship involving a preposition, with more flexibility in the meaning:

"I will listen to you."

"I will listen for you."

"I will listen after you."

"I will listen over you."

Intransitive verbs (verbs that need a preposition) often involve what an individual person or character thinks, wants, feels, intends, and tries, not simply what can be observed mechanically.

You often cannot detect the "internal" processes around intransitive verbs. You can tell if someone hears a bell. You usually cannot tell if someone is "listening for" a bell while they are doing something else, any more than you can tell if they clearly, or ambiguously, or ambivalently, wish or want or intent or try or fearfully or eagerly anticipate the bell.

In the same way, the transitive word describes what you can observe "factually" from the outside, and the intransitive (preposition using) words tend to describe what you usually cannot see concretely as an outside observer. For example, someone can pretend to be surprised or not surprised. Someone cannot pretend to hear the ring and pick up the phone.

Eithics:

There is also an ethical or practical aspect to this. You can ask someone to look, but you cannot ask them to see. You can ask them to listen, but you can't ask them to hear. You can ask them to study, but you cannot ask them to learn. But you can *hope* that someone hears, sees, and learns.

Spatial Context:

The main "exception" to this pattern falls into the other pattern, being descriptions of physical three dimensional space, where the "external" description *should* have a preposition in order to be clear. The statement, "You need to ~~go the bridge~~." does not contain enough information to be helpful.